



YOU ARE **36 WEEKS AND 1 DAY**
27 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

When scanned, this baby was lying with their back to their mother's. This “back to back” position is common at this stage but becomes less so as the pregnancy continues. Your doctor will be able to feel for the position of your baby's back from this point on.

“You're in the home stretch now. This can be a relief but also a time of mixed emotions.”

If you're lucky enough to have the opportunity to start maternity leave at this point, take advantage of it. As you leave your working role, the reality of beginning your role as a mother may hit you—but hopefully you will have a few more weeks to get used to the idea!

It can be a welcome respite to take it easy and not have to rush around in the mornings, and you'll feel less tired by not having to travel to work. Although you need to take it easy, it's a good idea to plan some outings during the daytime, as not having a routine can take some getting used to. Although it's good to stay in touch with colleagues, try not to fall into the trap of logging on to work email or staying up-to-date with what's happening at work. You might be worrying about losing some of your identity while you're on maternity leave; this is a common feeling, but you'll find that before you know it, your leave is over and you're settled back into work again.

Try to enjoy this lead-up to the birth and make the most of the time (see [Making the most of maternity leave](#)) to get organized and prepare for your new arrival.

ASK A DOCTOR

Will I feel different when my baby drops? Breathing will be easier, as your lungs have room to expand. Your abdomen may seem smaller, with your belly shifting down and forward, as your baby's head enters the birth canal. You may have more pelvic pain and may need to urinate more.

WHEN YOUR BABY ENGAGES

Engagement is the process by which your baby's head moves through the pelvic brim and into the birth canal in preparation for birth, and this can occur any time in these final few weeks of pregnancy, until the start of your labor. In the last weeks of pregnancy, your doctor will check to see if the head has started to engage, or drop, sometimes called “lightening.”